Zipper Smarts

Most zipper troubles are small, mechanical, and fixable at the kitchen table. Work through the symptoms below in order.

What you need: A pencil, needle-nose pliers or your fingers, needle and thread, and if the pull is toast: an old keyring or a paper clip.

Symptom: zipper won't stay closed

1. This is almost always a loose slider. Find the zipper stop at the very top of the tape and gently pry it off with pliers.
2. Squeeze the slider's back plate gently with the pliers, a small pinch on each side. Slightly tight is what you want.
3. Pull the slider down to test on the teeth, tighten again if needed.
4. Squeeze the stop back on at the top, or stitch over the top of the tape with thread to make a new stop.

Symptom: zipper separates behind the pull

1. The slider teeth are too wide apart. Same fix as above: touch the slider's back with pliers, one gentle squeeze per side.
2. Check the teeth where they pass through. Bend a few straight with your fingertips, making sure they all point the same way.

Symptom: fabric caught in the zipper

1. Stop. Don't yank.
2. Hold the fabric taut with one hand and ease the slider gently back down the tape to release it.
3. If it's really stuck, work a drop of dish soap into the mesh, let it sit a moment, then ease the slider back.

Symptom: pull tab is broken off

1. Open a loop of a paper clip or a keyring wider, and hook it through the little hole where the pull was.
2. Close it back up. In a few seconds you have a pull again, more comfortable than most original pulls.

Kind tips: If nothing above works, the zipper tape itself can be replaced as a weekend project with a sewing machine, or by a tailor for the price of two coffees. A rescued zipper is a good week.